

Body dysmorphic disorder (BDD)

BDD is an anxiety disorder that involves obsessive thoughts which distort a person's view of how they look. People with BDD may spend a lot of time in front of the mirror, perhaps focusing on one or more parts of their body, or constantly compare their appearance to that of others. Often other people don't see the problem, yet the self-perceived flaw causes so much concern for the BDD sufferer that it can restrict their enjoyment of life.



△ Feelings, not facts

Low body confidence can cause teens to see themselves in a distorted way.

GOOD TO KNOW

Bigorexia

"Bigorexia" (muscle dysmorphia) is a particular type of BDD. It usually affects boys and men. People with this condition see themselves as small and weak, despite being big and muscular. People with bigorexia exercise excessively to build muscle, neglect friendships in order to work out, and may even use steroids in pursuit of their ideal body shape.

Negative body image

Many teens aren't even aware that they have negative opinions about their own bodies, which crop up in either their thoughts or in conversation with others. Developed over time, it often becomes a habit that is hard to break.

A good first step, however, is to recognize the pattern behind the negative comments. Directly addressing such feelings begins the process of figuring out where they come from.

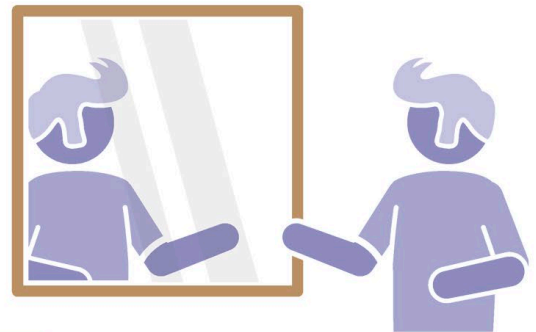
PARENT TIPS

Supporting your teen

- Speak positively about your own body image, especially around your teen.
- Encourage them to focus on being fit and healthy, rather than on achieving a goal weight or shape.
- Make clear that images in the media are usually enhanced, and that there is no such thing as a perfect body.
- Be supportive of your teen's changing body, but let them take the lead in conversations, to ensure they feel at ease.

Improving body image

It's possible to improve a teen's body image. It can take time, because it's really about changing their self-perception. This can make a big difference to how good a person feels about themselves. The most important thing is for a teen to learn to embrace their uniqueness as, over time, this will reinforce a healthy body image and strong self-esteem.



▷ Unique you

Teens should focus on something they like about their appearance each time they look in the mirror.

TEEN HINTS

Boosting body confidence

- Speak to yourself as a friend might and point out every day three compliments they would give to you about your body—and your personal qualities, too.
- Moving your body makes you feel good. Figure out what's fun for you, such as running, swimming, or dancing.
- If negative feelings become overwhelming, talk about them with an adult you trust.